

PROJECT POLARIS

Roadmap to a trusted private alpha

A practical desk reference for turning a local astrophotography advisor into a small, evidence-led product.

NORTH STAR

Make astrophotography simpler without taking away the wonder of discovering the universe.

Version 1 | July 2026 | Internal planning document

The shortest credible path

Polaris already has a working local advisory engine. The next step is not to add every good idea. It is to validate one repeatable habit: a smart-telescope user opens Polaris before imaging, understands the recommendation, and comes back because it made the night easier.

CURRENT STATE v1.6 local Working single-observatory product	WORK CADENCE 10-14 hr/wk Focused sessions, not a full-time team	PRIVATE ALPHA TARGET Oct-Nov 2026 10-20 invited users
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TIMELINE

NOW v1.6 local closeout	Finish and validate the real local capture-to-learning loop.
LATE JULY - EARLY AUG Discovery + alpha architecture	Learn the real pain; decide the smallest safe hosted design.
AUGUST - SEPTEMBER Build the hosted nightly loop	Onboard, recommend, explain, and collect useful feedback.
OCTOBER - NOVEMBER Private alpha	Invite 10-20 users only after the core flow is reliable.
DECEMBER - FEBRUARY Closed beta decision	Expand carefully if evidence shows repeat use and trust.

The decision rule: do not publicly launch because a feature list feels complete. Launch only when real users repeatedly trust Polaris to reduce a real planning problem.

What each milestone must prove

Dates are planning ranges. Each version exits only when its user-facing result is credible, not merely when its code compiles.

MILESTONE	OUTCOME	EXIT TEST
v1.6 Now - early Aug	Close the local single-user loop: plan, capture, ingest, review, and learn.	Doug can complete that loop without manual database work.
Discovery 2 weeks	Log user pain and select one minimal hosted-product architecture.	A written decision covers tenancy, security, deployment, data, backups, and monitoring.
v1.7 Mid-late Aug	Add accounts, data isolation, secure configuration, and a deployable baseline.	Two users cannot access or alter each other's observatory data.
v1.8 Late Aug-mid Sep	Build mobile-friendly onboarding and the hosted tonight recommendation loop.	A new user reaches a credible recommendation without Doug's help.
v1.9 Mid-late Sep	Make feedback, support, privacy basics, and reliability part of the product.	Doug and 2-3 trusted testers use the core loop repeatedly without a critical failure.
v1.10 Oct-Nov	Run private alpha with 10-20 invited smart-telescope users.	Users return, understand the advice, and say they would miss Polaris.
v2.0 Dec-Feb	Run a controlled closed beta, expanding only on evidence.	Service is stable and evidence supports continued investment or a change in direction.

What deliberately waits: native iOS/Android apps, subscriptions, broad device support, advanced image-processing workflows, and large feature expansion. They earn their place after the alpha proves repeat use.

How we keep the mountain small

The plan should reduce overwhelm, not create more administration. We will use it to choose the next 100 feet of the climb.

Every time Doug says Start coding timer, the session begins with:

1	Current position Version, active milestone, and a short recap of what changed in the last few sessions.
2	One outcome for today One clear result sized for the available 1-2 hour session, with only the next one or two tasks.
3	Reality check Expected time, a real blocker, and the reason today matters to the private-alpha path.
4	Close the loop Test, commit when appropriate, update the timer, and name the next smallest step.

Completed foundation

DONE	Planner V3 produces chronological, equipment-aware advisory schedules.
DONE	The operator dashboard separates tonight, portfolio, quality, history, data status, and location planning.
DONE	Real capture ingestion now updates integration, history, and quality without changing the scientific source data.
DONE	Backup checks, startup preflight, release gates, and a running project-time log protect the local product.
DONE	Quality Scoring v2 and the goal engine are active v1.6 work, while product discovery and naming are documented separately.

Project-manager commitment: I will flag scope creep, distinguish facts from guesses, and recommend the smallest useful next step. We will not solve future problems before there is evidence they are real.